

The First Kiss: Twenty-One Million Years Ago [B1]

Il bacio è il gesto che, più di tutti, rappresenta l'amore. Ma perché ci bacciamo? Secondo uno studio, tutto avrebbe avuto inizio circa 21 milioni di anni fa, all'epoca dei nostri antenati primati.

A kiss, they say, is the shortest distance between two hearts. We all remember our first kiss, that sense of anticipation and curiosity, a [pivotal](#) part of our emotional (and sexual) development. However, although most people probably consider kissing an exclusively human [behaviour](#), used to express romance and affection, a new study suggests that the first kissers were ancient primates that lived [up to](#) twenty-one million years ago.

CHIMPANZEES KISS, TOO!

Our earliest record of human kissing is from 4,500 years ago, preserved on thousands of [clay](#) tablets that have survived the test of time. The tablets from ancient Mesopotamia document kissing as a common practice in both romantic and platonic relationships. Humans are not the only species that kiss, however. Kissing has also been observed among other primates, including chimpanzees, bonobos, orangutans, and one species of gorilla. Now a new University of Oxford study, led by evolutionary biologist Dr. Matilda Brindle, has examined when kissing first evolved.

HOW DO YOU SAY...?

Parole al vento. Lip service.

AN ANCIENT PRACTICE

Brindle's team of researchers used phylogenetic analysis — the study of evolutionary relationships among organisms, typically using data such as DNA sequences — to study the shared [ancestry](#) of primates, and statistical

modelling to estimate the probability that various ancient primates kissed. What they discovered is that kissing is an ancient [behaviour](#) that [likely](#) originated in the common ancestor of humans and large [apes](#) between 21.5 and 16.9 million years ago. Entertainment

Learning With Music: Top 10 Love Songs Non c'è niente di più romantico che dedicare una canzone d'amore. Eccone 10 intramontabili con cui fare colpo! Fergal Kavanagh , Sarah Davison

INTERSPECIES

This means that not only ancient animals but also the extinct human species known as Neanderthals probably practised kissing. And it's possible that Neanderthals and our early Homo sapiens ancestors kissed each other, since the two species [interbred](#) tens of thousands of years ago.

NOT GOOD FOR SURVIVAL

The study answers some questions about kissing but leaves others unanswered, [most notably](#): why did primates begin kissing in the first place? Most [behaviours](#) evolve to help species survive and prosper. But kissing can in fact have a detrimental effect on survival because it facilitates the transmission of [disease](#). Another study, published in 2022, found that kissing probably contributed to the [spread](#) of the herpes virus HSV-1 in Europe around five thousand years ago. Brindle hopes other researchers will conduct their own studies to find out not when kissing evolved, but why. She told CNN, "What we've done, which is a really important first step, is showing it's an [evolved trait](#). It's really ancient. But why? And that's the amazing next step if people want to [pick up the mantle](#)."

Glossary

- **spread** = diffusione
- **pick up the mantle** = raccogliere il testimone
- **pivotal** = cruciale
- **behaviour** = comportamento
- **clay** = argilla
- **likely** = probabilmente
- **apes** = scimmie
- **most notably** = soprattutto
- **evolved trait** = tratto evoluto
- **up to** = fino a
- **ancestry** = lignaggio, antenati
- **interbred** = incrociarsi, accoppiarsi
- **disease** = malattia